Oedi

By Rich Orloff

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR 1:*** *Town Crier, Creon and Jocasta* ***ACTOR 2:*** *Oedipus*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

TOWN CRIER: (Pg 162-178) *(off stage)* Hear ye, hear ye! _____o'clock and all is well. For the best in dining delicacies, treat yourself to Hecuba's House of Hummus! Try their babagonoosh!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 2: *Welcome to Ancient Greece and the city of Thebes – the birthplace of the infamous Oedipus.*
ACTOR 1: *Before he was even born, the oracle at Delphi (both gesture in some way to the gods) told his parents that the boy would grow up to kill his father and marry his mother. (shocked gasp)*
ACTOR 2: *So . . . his parents did what many people with unwanted children did in the past.*
ACTOR 1: *They had the baby's feet spiked and hired a herdsman to abandon the child in the wild. (both shrug)*
ACTOR 2: *The kind-hearted herdsman just couldn't do it. Instead, he gave baby Oedipus to a childless king and queen in Corinth and they raised Oedipus as their own.*
ACTOR 1: *(in an ominous voice) But one cannot circumvent the will of the gods! (thunderclap)*
ACTOR 2: *Okay, enough with the dramatic. Our story opens with Oedipus as an adult finding out the news of who he truly is.*
ACTOR 1: *This is Sophocles' story of Oedipus from the comedic imaginings of Rich Orloff*
ACTOR 2: *. . . Oedi! Come on down!*

OEDIPUS: Creon, my trusted aide, you have returned! Ever since the plague has hit our beloved Thebes, the people insist that we find the killer of their former king. They are convinced that until we punish the murderer, the plague shall continue. As their new king, I owe them the truth. Besides, the latest polls show my popularity's plummeting. I created the Creon Commission to ferret out the facts of this fearsome felony, and I demand to

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

know what you have learned.

CREON: Well, first we visited the oracles of Delphi. They [told] us that King Laios was murdered by his own son!

OEDIPUS: But that's crazy. Laios had no son.

CREON: Actually, he did, many years ago, but the child was banished as an infant. People assumed the child died in the wilderness.

OEDIPUS: Poor child. I feel his pain, as if it were my own.

CREON: Funny you should say that. We learned the child had been rescued by a shepherd a grew up to be about your height, your weight, and according to descriptions, he looked a lot like you.

OEDIPUS: What a coincidence.

CREON: Oedipus, how to put this... You know how much I admire you. When you first came to town, it was I who encouraged the people to make you king. (beat) You never murdered anyone, did you? Say, kill anyone on your journey here?

OEDIPUS: Let me recall. I decided it was time to leave Corinth and seek my fortune in the world. So I decided to journey to Thebes. When I got to the town of Phokis, I met a hostile band of travellers. One of them called me a mama's boy, so I clubbed them all to death. Other than that, I didn't kill anyone.

CREON: For that you clubbed him to death? Well, Oedipus, I don't know how to tell you this, but we learned that King Laios was clubbed to death in the town of Phokis.

OEDIPUS: You're not suggesting I - I'd never kill a king. It's - It's inappropriate.

CREON: He was on a religious pilgrimage. . . He always dressed down for those things.

OEDIPUS: Then it's possible But Tiresias prophesied that Laios would be killed by his own son. I never even met the man before.

CREON: Oedipus, we discovered Polybus and Merope weren't your real parents. You're an orphan. We also know that the son of Laios had a birthmark in the shape of an olive on the bottom of his left foot. *[Creon stares at Oedipus' left foot.]*

OEDIPUS: But I hate taking off my sandals. It always takes so long to lace them back up.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

[Oedipus unlaces his left sandal and lifts his left foot. On the bottom of his foot is a birthmark in the shape of a huge green olive with a red pimento.] As you can see, my foot has no such mark.

CREON: Oedi, admit it. That's an olive.

OEDIPUS: I prefer to think of it as an unripe eggplant with ketchup on it.

CREON: It's an olive.

OEDIPUS: Okay, okay. Technically speaking, it's an olive. Oh, woe to me and those who dwell in my house! I've slain a king, and I promised the people I'd put the killer to death. I even said, "Read my lips." But wait! One thing isn't clear.

CREON: Here comes the messy part.

OEDIPUS: If I'm Laios' son, and if Laios was married to Jocasta, who is now my wife, that means, that means, that means - Laios must've had a previous wife, right?

CREON: I'm afraid not.

OEDIPUS: Ever fool around on the side?

CREON: Never.

OEDIPUS: Sperm donor?

CREON: Nope.

OEDIPUS: Oh my gods! Oh my gods! I've married my mother!! No wonder she always knows what I want for breakfast. Oh my gods! I've murdered my father and married my mother! Oh, wretched day! Oh, cursed life! How can I expunge the evil deed from my soul? There is only one way! I must pluck out my eyes immediately! *[Oedipus tries to pluck out his eyes, but Creon holds his arms back.]*

CREON: Don't do it! You'll have a moment's satisfaction, and a lifetime of wondering if your toga's on straight.

OEDIPUS: Okay, okay. Let go...Does my beloved wife know about this?

CREON: Not yet.

JOCASTA: *[off stage]* Yoo-hoo, oh, Oedi!

CREON: The queen approaches. *[Creon exits]*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

OEDIPUS: *[Calling out]* In here, snookums!

[Jocasta enters. She's easily thirty or more years older than Oedipus. If she happens to be short and speaks with a slight old world inflection, so much the better.]

OEDIPUS: Jocasta, I must tell you something most horrible, worse than the most terrible news you could imagine.

JOCASTA: You didn't like my brisket last night?

OEDIPUS: That's not it.

JOCASTA: My toga's too short, isn't it? You think a woman my age . . .

OEDIPUS: Your toga's fine.

JOCASTA: Are we having problems I'm unaware of in the horizontal department?

OEDIPUS: No, everything's fine in the - Jocasta, I just received the report of the Creon Commission.

JOCASTA: Oh, good. As soon as we name the murderer of Laios and make him drink some seltzer with a shpritz of hemlock, I know your approval rating will bounce right back.

OEDIPUS: I don't think so. Jocasta. . . The murderer of your late husband stands before you.

JOCASTA: You killed Laios? Oh, no! Horror of horrors! I suddenly feel like plucking

OEDIPUS: Don't pluck your eyes out!

JOCASTA: No, I feel like plucking a chicken. I'm so stressed. How are we going to put a spin on this so the public doesn't hate you?

OEDIPUS: Don't you hate me?

JOCASTA: How can I hate you for something I thought of doing every single day of our marriage?

OEDIPUS: I thought you loved him.

JOCASTA: What's to love? The man snored, he had bad breath, and when I think of the things he made me do . . . the news is not that bad at all.

OEDIPUS: But I have not told you all of it. Jocasta, you remember the prophecy of Tiresias that your husband would be murdered by your son?

JOCASTA: Yes, also remember he prophesied. . .The Iliad would never make it as a novel.

OEDIPUS: [Well], there's reason to believe that, by some ferocious folly of the fates, you

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

married your own son.

JOCASTA: So? Tell me something I don't know. From the first moment you came into town. I took one look at those eyes, that smile, that - oh, wait a second, you have a little shmutz on your forehead. *[Jocasta licks her fingers and begins to wipe Oedi's forehead.]*

OEDIPUS: Stop that! How could you know I was your son and not tell me?

JOCASTA: I didn't think it was significant.

OEDIPUS: You married me!

JOCASTA: You asked. I would've been happy just dating; you were the one in a hurry. "Marry me, Jocasta, and I'll be the happiest man on earth." What mother could refuse such an offer?

OEDIPUS: But I killed Dad!

JOCASTA: So? He never liked you anyway. Once he heard Tiresias' prediction that you were destined to murder him, he insisted you be sent away. I said, "Can't we wait and see? Maybe he'll just wound you a little." Look, you're here and all is well, so unless there's some more news, I want to get to my belly dancercize class. I need to be in ship shape.

OEDIPUS: Don't you think we have some issues to discuss?

JOCASTA: Like what?

OEDIPUS: Like the fact that we can no longer live as husband and wife.

JOCASTA: Why not?

OEDIPUS: Because you're my mother!

JOCASTA: You say that like it's a negative.

OEDIPUS: Men cannot marry their mothers!

JOCASTA: From what I've heard, most men marry women who remind them of their mothers. Why settle for second best when you can have the real thing?

OEDIPUS: No! I want to be with a woman to whom I'm ***not*** already related. I'm a public official. I'm a role model.

JOCASTA: So? Look at the Gods. Zeus has slept with his half-sister, his quarter-sister, his sixteenth- sister. If our own gods get to boff their relatives, why can't you?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

OEDIPUS: Because you're my mother!

JOCASTA: Must you make everything so complex, Oedipus? Look, Oedi, I understand this is traumatic for you. But in a healthy marriage, you work through these things.

OEDIPUS: We don't have a healthy marriage! Mom. . . I want a divorce.

JOCASTA: *[breaks into hysterical crying]* I never thought I'd hear such a thing from my own son. Call in your advisor. See what he says.

OEDIPUS: Get me Creon! *[CREON enters]*

CREON: I have been busy, my lord, making some initial inquiries into public response to the crisis: The people are confused. 85% of those polled strongly agreed with the statement, "If two people love each other, nothing else in a marriage is important." But 54% also believe that those who commit incest should be boiled alive in non-virgin olive oil.

OEDIPUS: I didn't know she was my mother, does it still fit the technical legal definition of incest?

CREON: Why don't you start a war? That's always a good distraction.

OEDIPUS: I'm not going to start a war just to boost my approval rating. There's only one answer which will prove to the people I show remorse for my sins. I must pluck out my eyes!

CREON: Wouldn't a sincere "I'm sorry" suffice?

OEDIPUS: No! Give me your golden pins. *[Oedi grabs two large pins from Jocasta's toga or hair.]*

CREON: Oedipus, don't!

OEDIPUS: Silence! Stand back*! [Raising the pins.]* I declare myself guilty of wretchedness and sin! From this hour forth, I go in darkness! *[Oedipus is about to plunge the pins into his eyes, but he stops at the last moment.]* Or . . . maybe I'll just cut off the offending organ which caused the sinful deed. That's it! I'll save my sight but lose my jewels. I declare myself guilty of wretchedness and sin! From this hour forth, I go in eunuchness! *[Oedipus is about to plunge the pins into his pelvic region, but stops at the last moment.]* Or . . . maybe I'll just cut off my arm. It's a more visible symbol anyway. My left arm, or maybe

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

just one of my fingers, since we're talking symbolic action!

CREON: You know, Oedipus, the more I think about it, the more I wonder, why are we driving ourselves into such a tizzy? You know how fickle the people are. Today they'll want to burn you at the stake; in a week, they'll be obsessed with the latest gossip about the gods. All we need is one good speech and a heartfelt explanation.

OEDIPUS: But how can we explain such a monstrous deed? Oh, what am I to do? If only the gods would give me a sign.

CREON: Maybe they have. Run with me a little. Tiresias saw your fate when you were born; you tried your best not to live it out, but there are powers beyond those of we poor mortals.

OEDIPUS: I get it! Any efforts to forswear malfeasance were futile; it was the fault of the fates! I'll make a speech where I'll take complete responsibility for my actions, but none of the blame.

CREON: We'll say you wanted to smite out your eyes, but you placed your sense of public duty ahead of

your own desires. *[Imagining the headline:]* "Oedipus Rex, Tragic Hero."

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rich Orloff
Book: The Best American Short Plays 1997-1998 (Edited by Glenn Young), Pgs 162-178
ISBN: 978-1557833655
Publisher: Applause Theatre Books
Date (Month/Year): May 2000

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
NIETOC

KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier